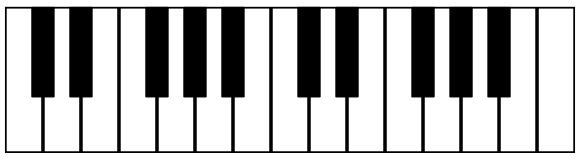
Read at Sight

A graded sight-reading course for piano

Volume 1 - First Steps



Middle C

Hundreds of short, new exercises at exactly your level,
with tips, checkpoints and real pieces along the way.

Exercises generated to graded rules; pieces are original or public domain.

How to use this book

Why this book is built this way

You get better at sight-reading by reading a lot of new music that is easy for you, not by struggling through hard pieces. So every unit gives you many short exercises that use only what you have learned so far, plus a few real pieces.

The five rules

1. Never stop: keep the beat going, even after a wrong note. 2. Count out loud and use a metronome at the speed shown. 3. Keep your eyes on the music, not your hands. 4. Read the shape: up, down, or the same, and by how much. 5. Play each exercise once, tick its box, and move on. Come back only after a few weeks.

Before every exercise: 10 seconds

Check the clef and time signature. Find the first note and its finger number. Scan for the highest and lowest note, and for any bar that repeats an earlier one. Then count one bar in and play.

How each unit is laid out

A unit opens with what is new, a keyboard picture of the hand position, and reading tips. Then come Parts A, B and C, which grow slightly harder. Pieces come next, and the unit ends with a checkpoint that tells you when to move on.

A daily routine (15-20 minutes)

Warm up by playing the five notes of the hand position up and down, saying their names (2 minutes). Read 6-10 new exercises, one pass each (10 minutes). Play one piece, aiming for steady and musical (5 minutes).

Contents

Each unit adds exactly one new idea to everything before it.

Unit 1 The Right Hand Finds Its Home 4
Treble clef, right hand C position, whole / half / quarter notes, 4/4

Unit 2 The Left Hand and the Bass Clef
Bass clef, left hand C position (C3-G3)

Unit 3 Hands Take Turns
Melody passes between hands; 3/4 time and the dotted half note

Unit 4 Skips
Thirds: line-to-line and space-to-space

Unit 5 Hands Together
Left hand holds C or G while the right hand moves

Unit 6 Middle C Position
Both thumbs on middle C; notes near the middle of the grand staff

Unit 7 Rests and Ties
Quarter, half and whole rests; ties across the bar line

Unit 8 G Position
Moving the hands to G; fourths and fifths

Unit 9 Eighth Notes
Two eighths per beat; counting 1-and-2-and

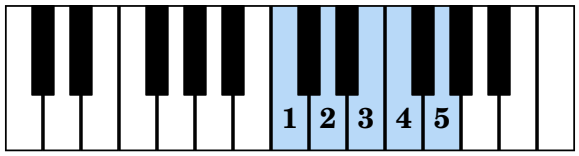
Unit 10 Sharps, Flats and Review
Sharps, flats and key signatures (D and F positions); review of Units 1-9

Unit 1

The Right Hand Finds Its Home

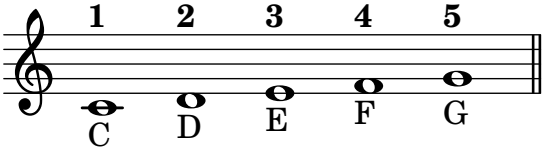
New: Treble clef, right hand C position, whole / half / quarter notes, 4/4

In this unit your right hand learns its first home on the keyboard: the C position. Put your right thumb (finger 1) on middle C and let fingers 2, 3, 4 and 5 rest on the next four white keys: D, E, F and G. Your hand does not move for the whole unit, so every note you read is already under a finger.



Right hand C position: finger numbers on the keys

Your five notes



What is new

The treble clef

The curl of the treble clef wraps around the second line from the bottom. That line is G, the note under your little finger.

Middle C

Middle C sits on its own short line (a ledger line) just below the treble staff. It is your thumb.

Lines and spaces

Notes alternate line, space, line, space as they go up: C (ledger line), D (space under the staff), E (bottom line), F (first space), G (second line).

Note values

Whole note = 4 beats (open, no stem). Half note = 2 beats (open, with stem). Quarter note = 1 beat (filled in, with stem).

4/4 time

The top 4 means four beats in every bar. Count 1 - 2 - 3 - 4 out loud, steadily, in every bar.

Reading tips

1. Read the direction, not the names. Ask: does the next note go up, down, or stay the same? A step goes from a line to the very next space (or space to line), and is always the next finger.

2. Keep your eyes on the page. Your fingers already sit on the right keys, so there is no need to look down.
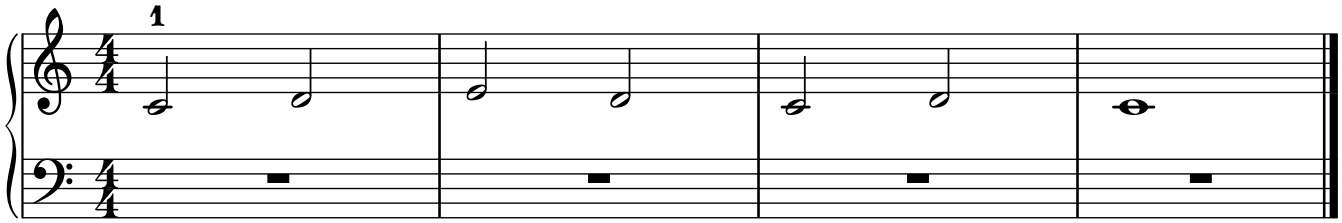
3. Count out loud and never stop. If you play a wrong note, keep going: the beat matters more than the note.

4. Before each exercise, take 10 seconds: find the starting note and finger, then scan for where the line goes up and where it goes down.
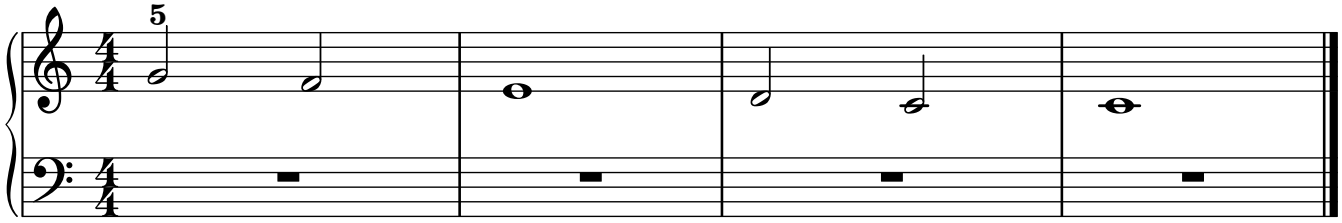
Part A: Whole and half notes ♩ = 60

Long notes only: whole notes (4 beats) and half notes (2 beats). Set the metronome to 60 and count every beat aloud.
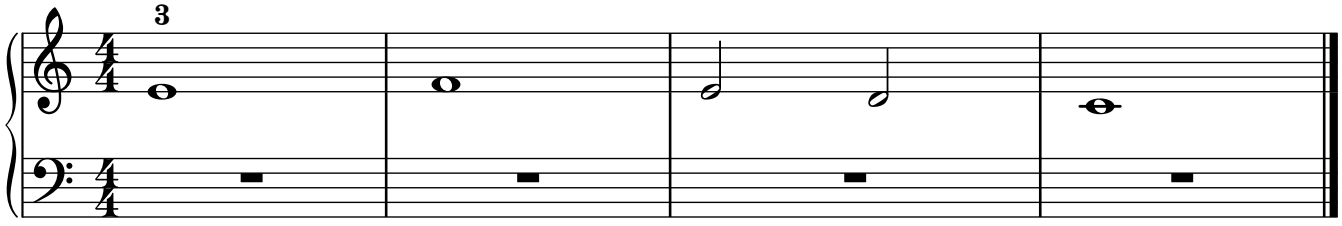
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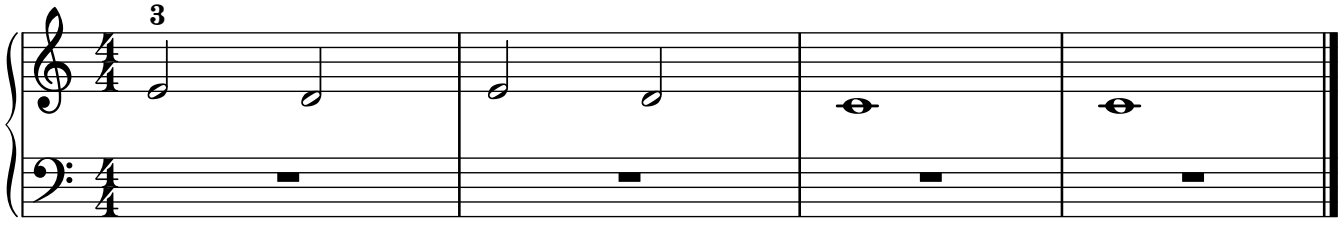
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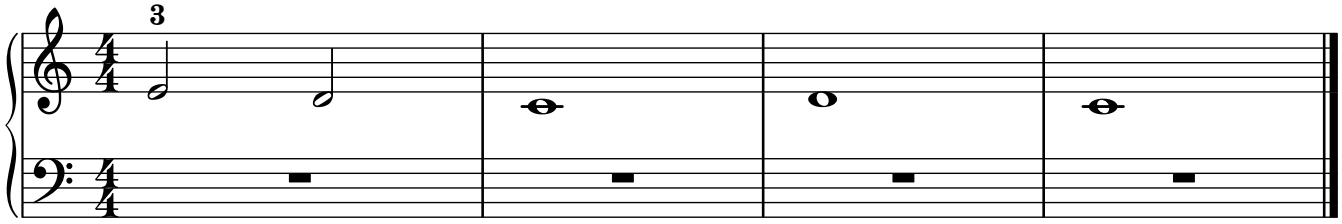
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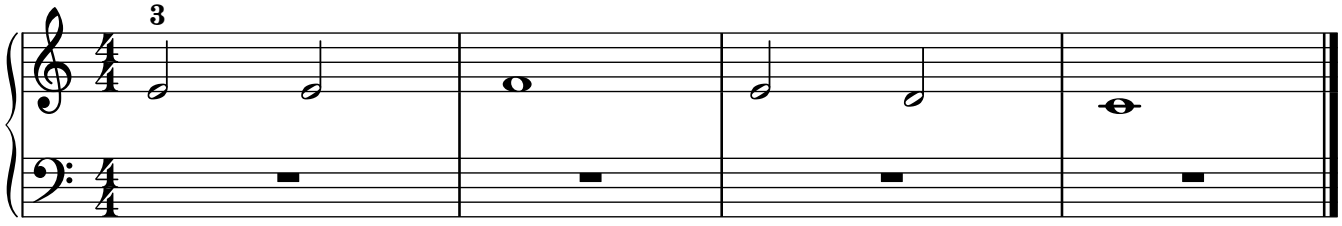


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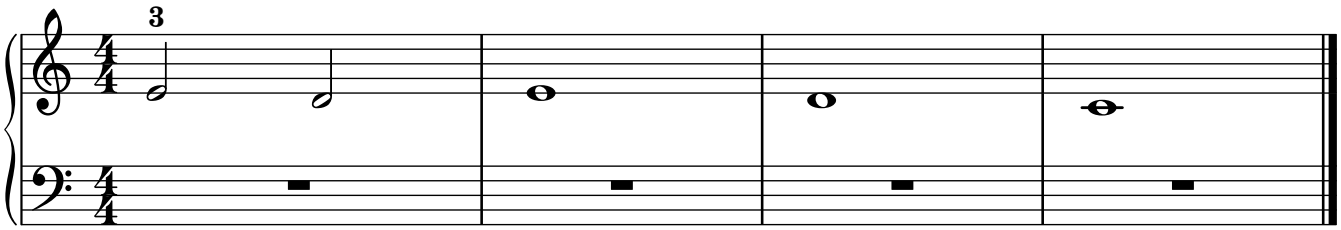
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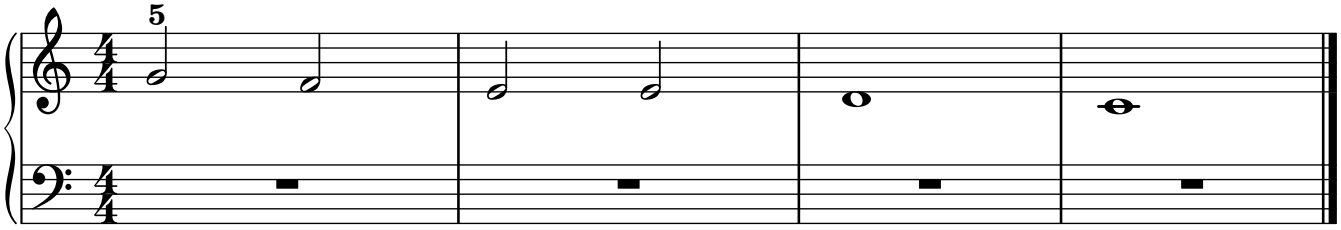
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☐ **1.7**



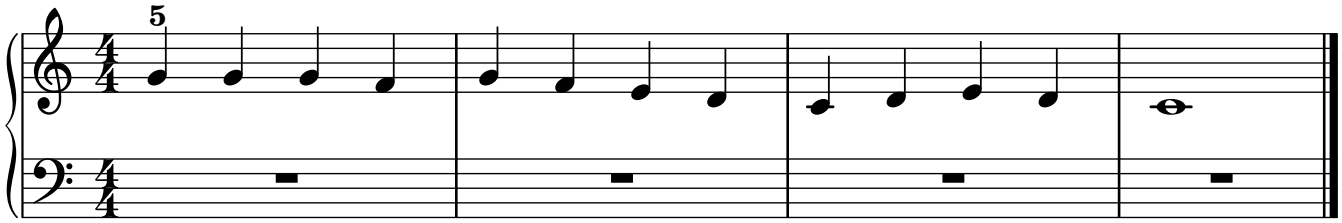
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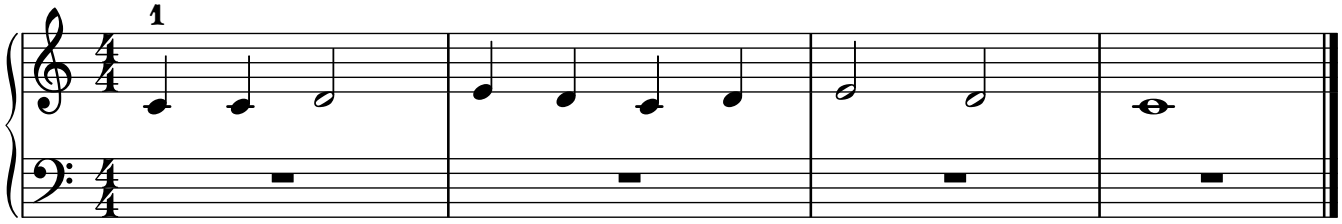
Part B: Quarter notes join in ♩ = 60

Now quarter notes (1 beat) join in. Keep the same steady 60. Notice how many exercises move in steps of a single finger.

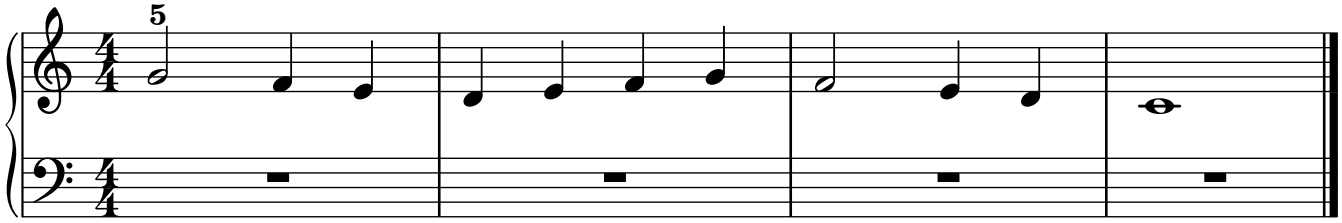
☐ **1.9**



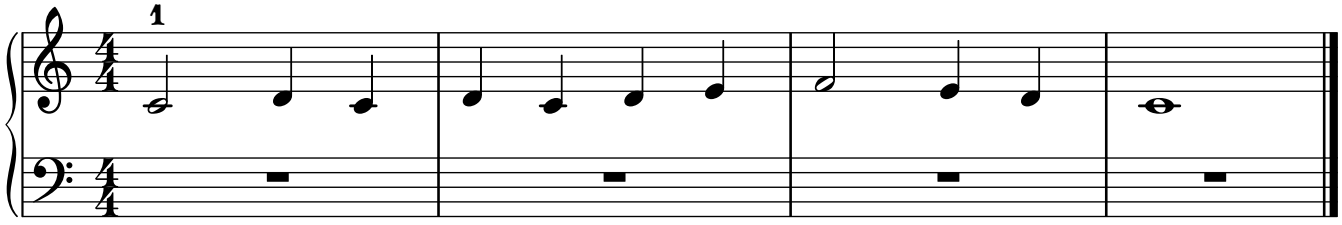
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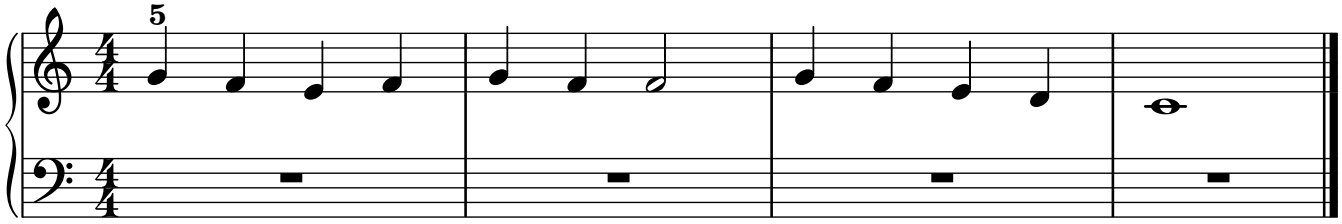
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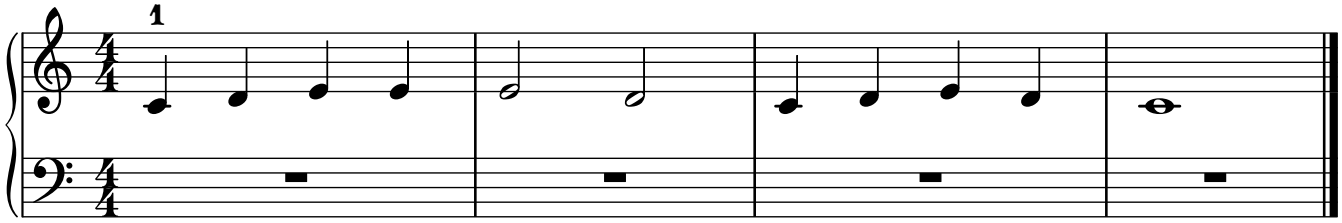
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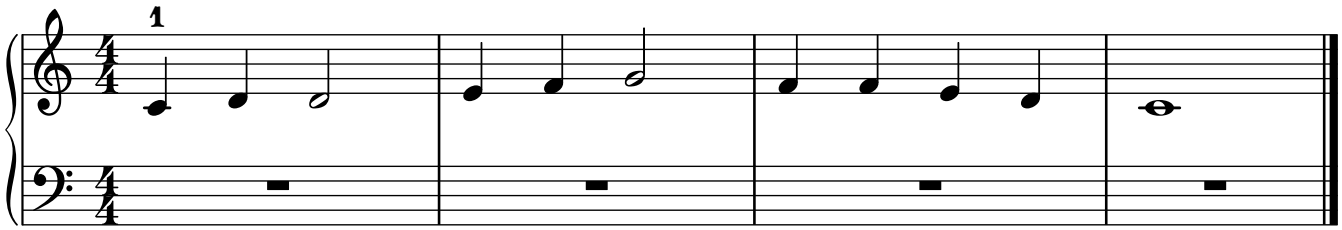
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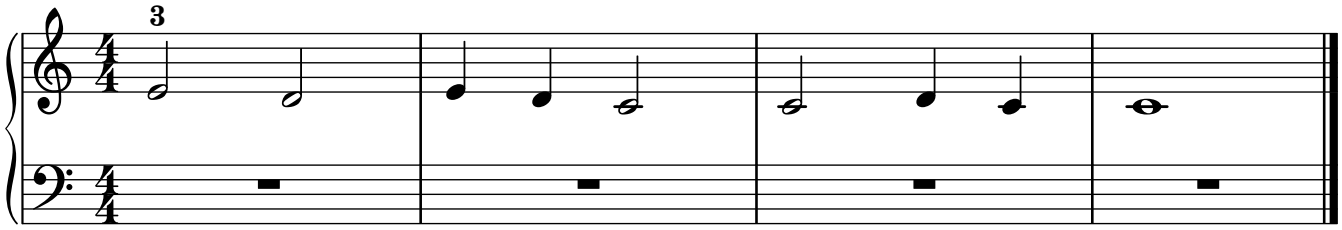
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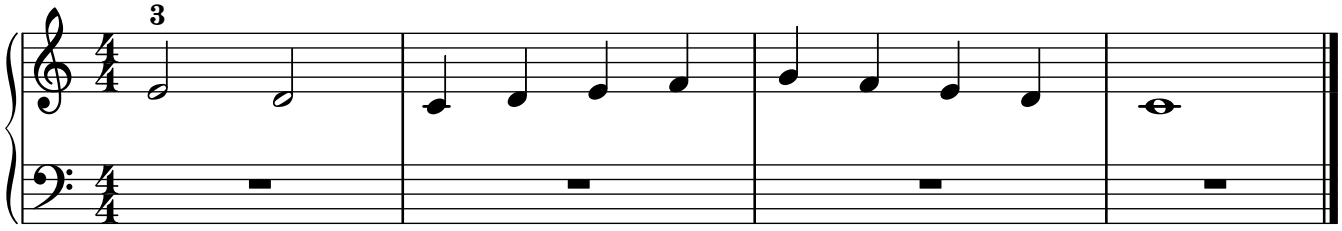


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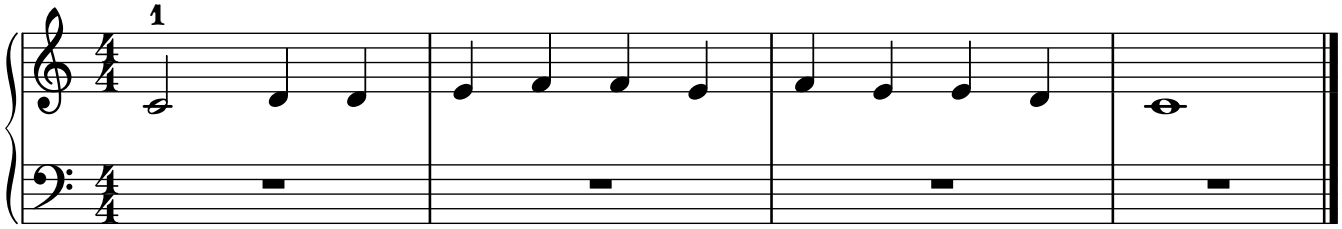
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☐ **1.17**



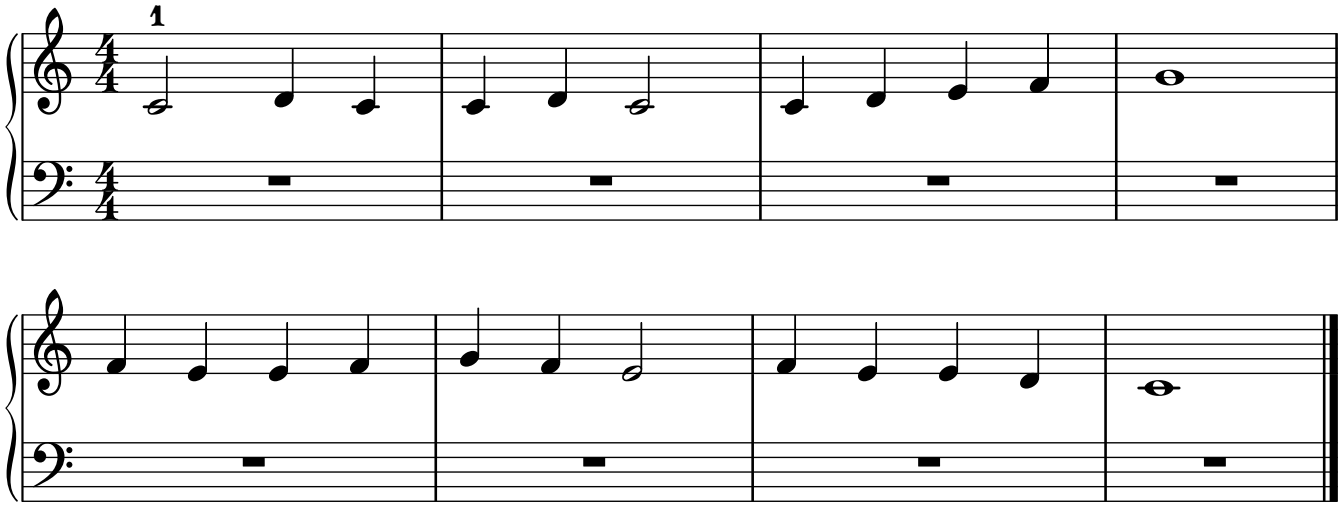
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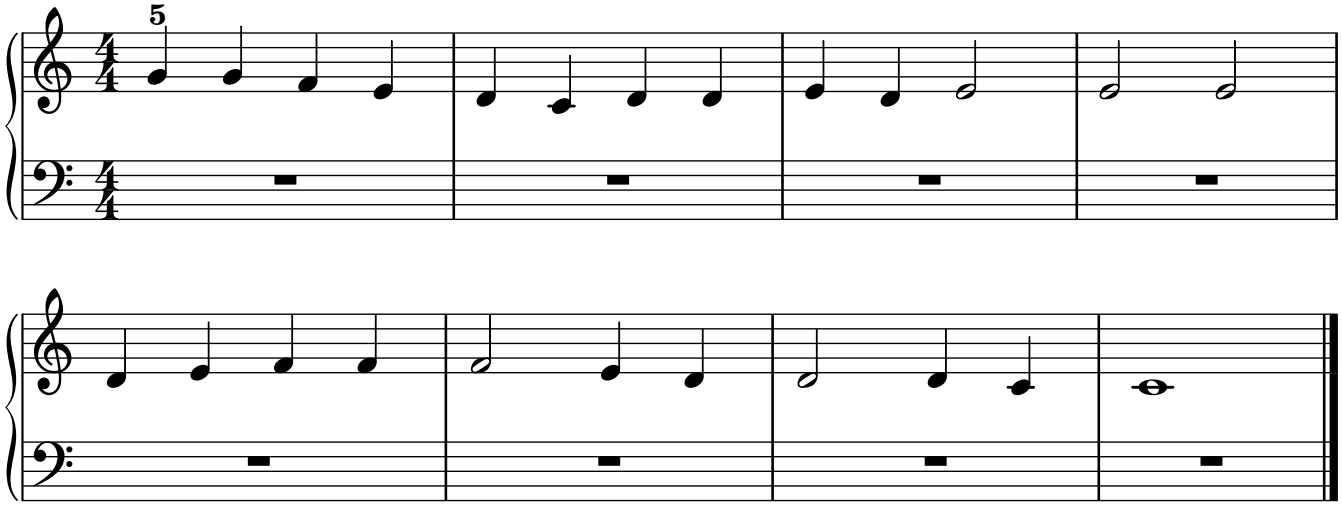


Part C: Eight-bar phrases ♩ = 66

Eight-bar phrases, written on two lines. Look for bars that repeat: many phrases restart in bar 5 the same way they began in bar 1. Spotting a repeat means less to read.
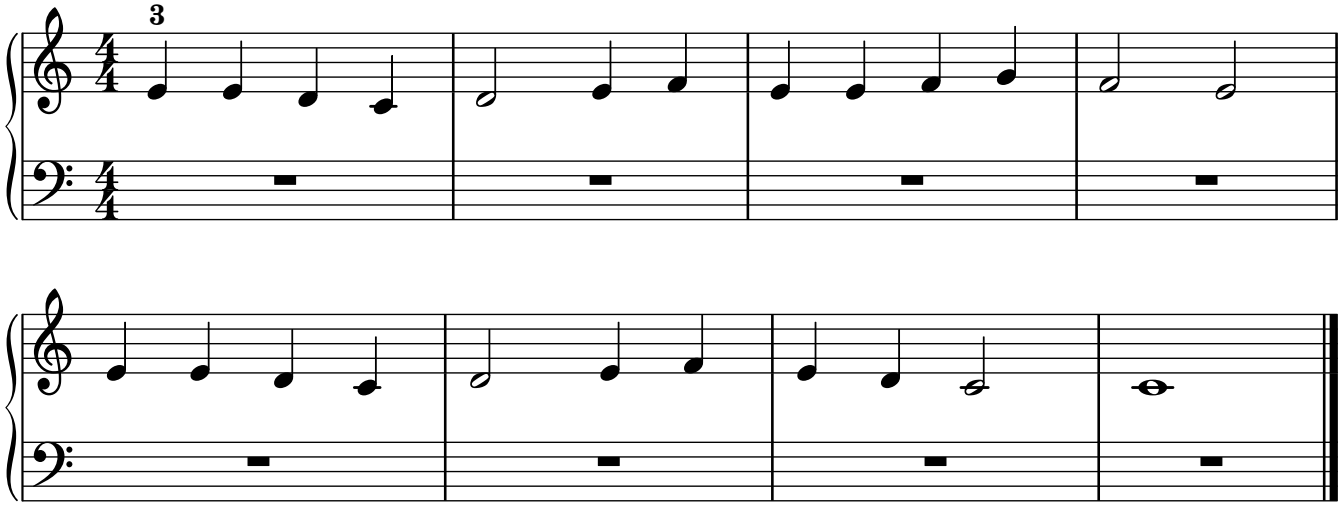
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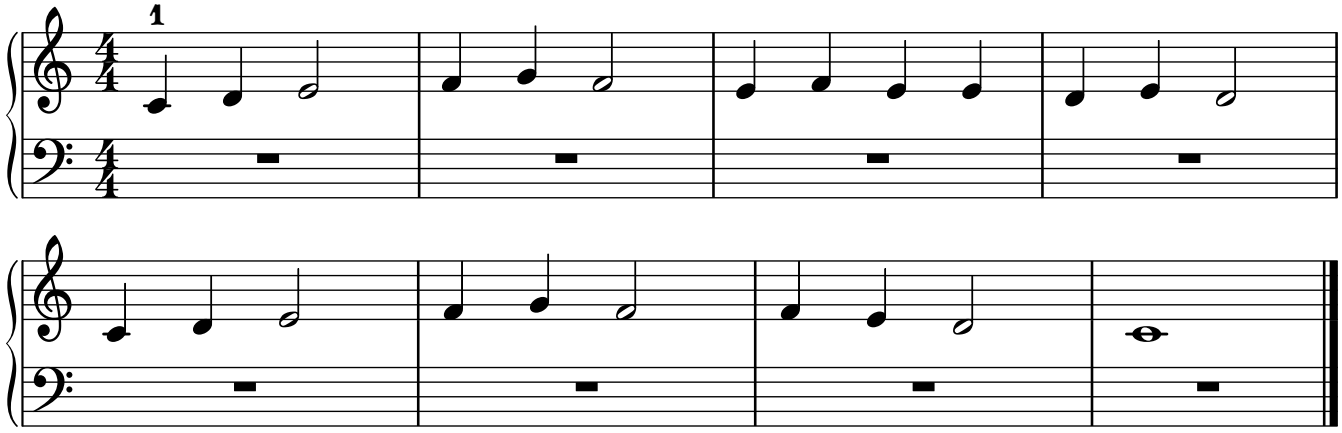
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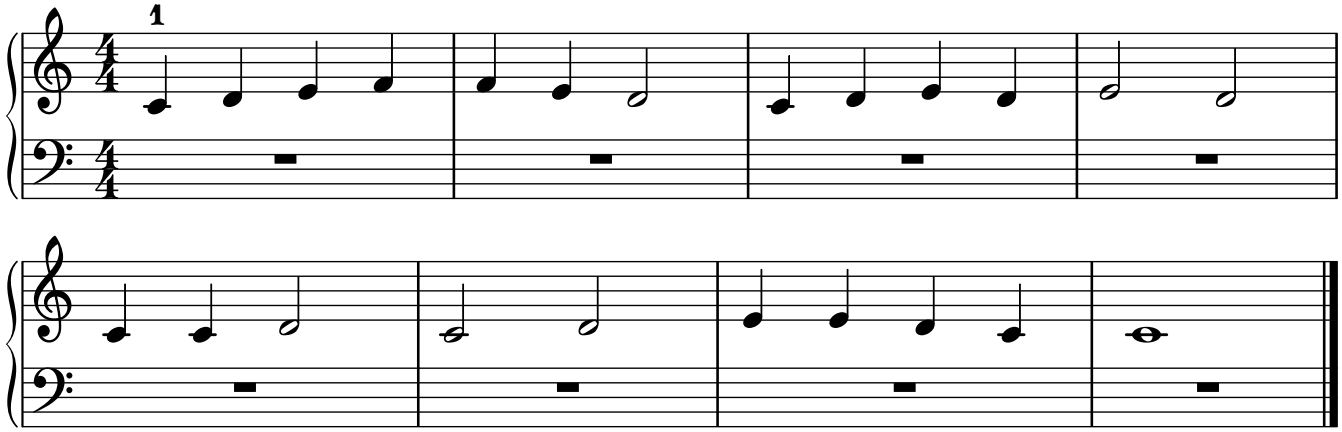


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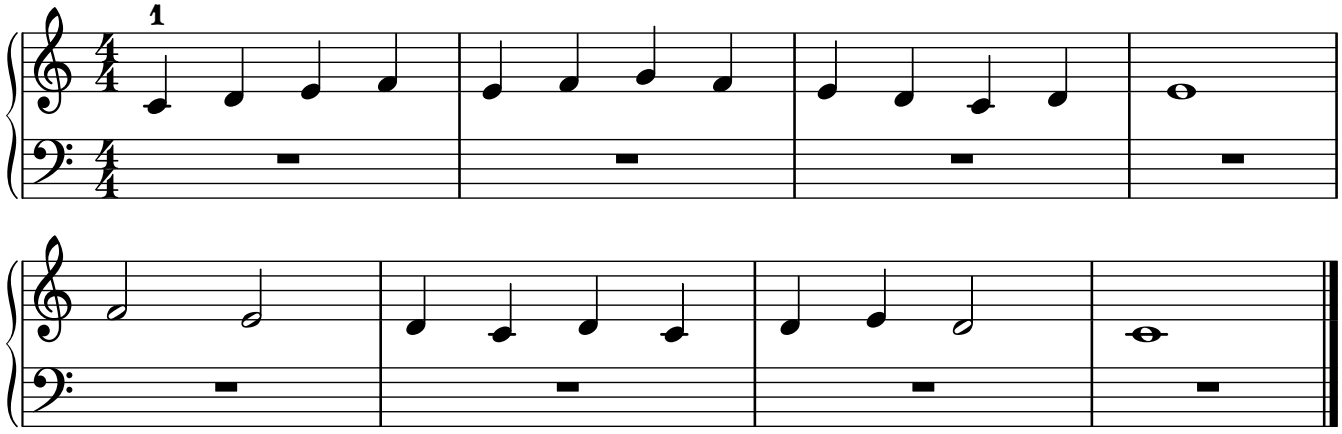
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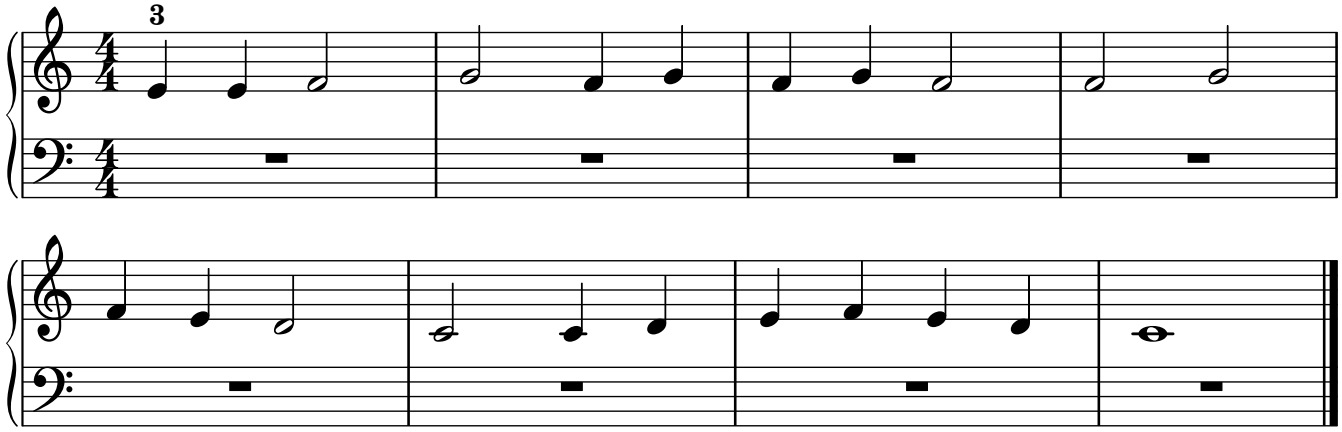


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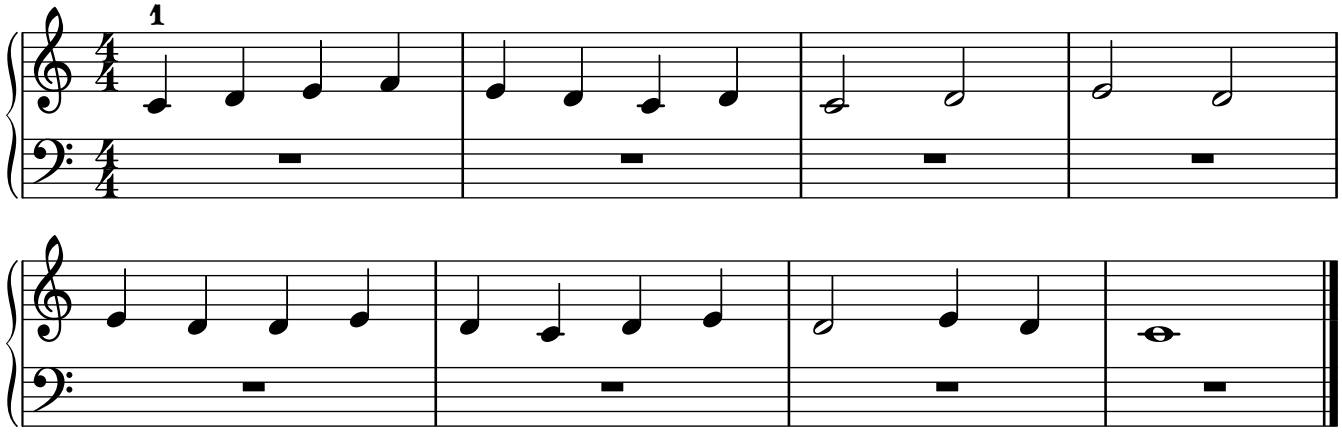
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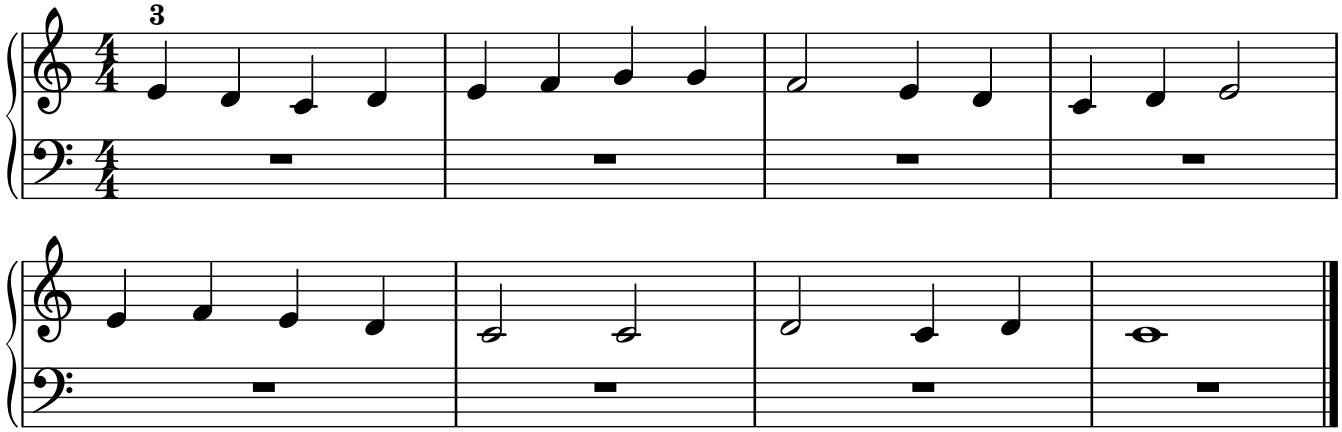


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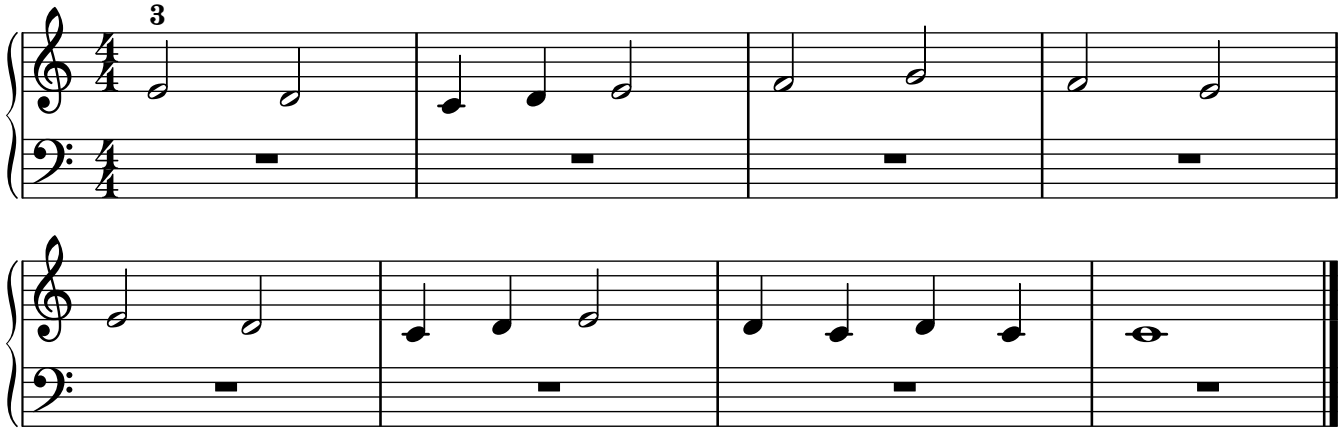


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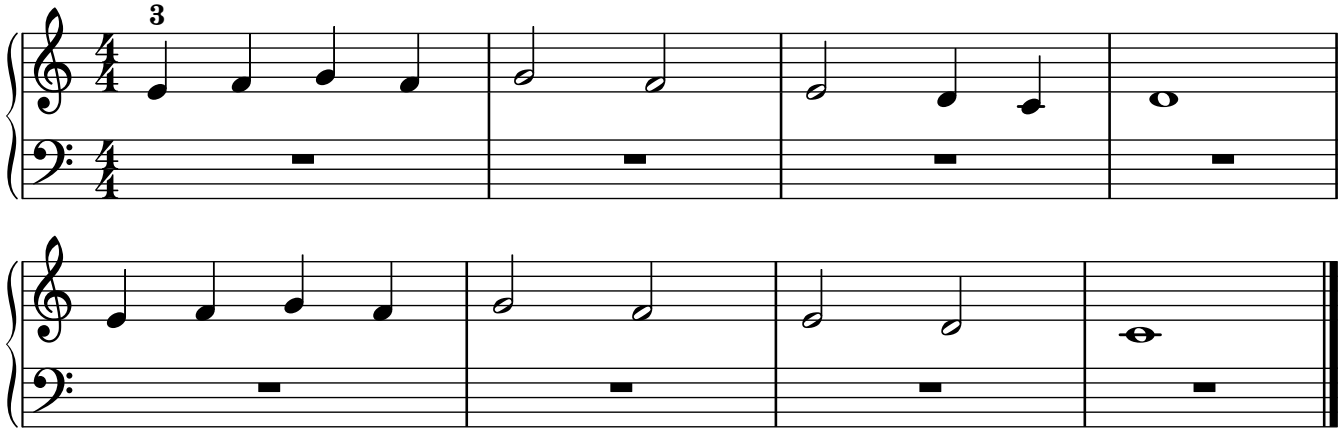
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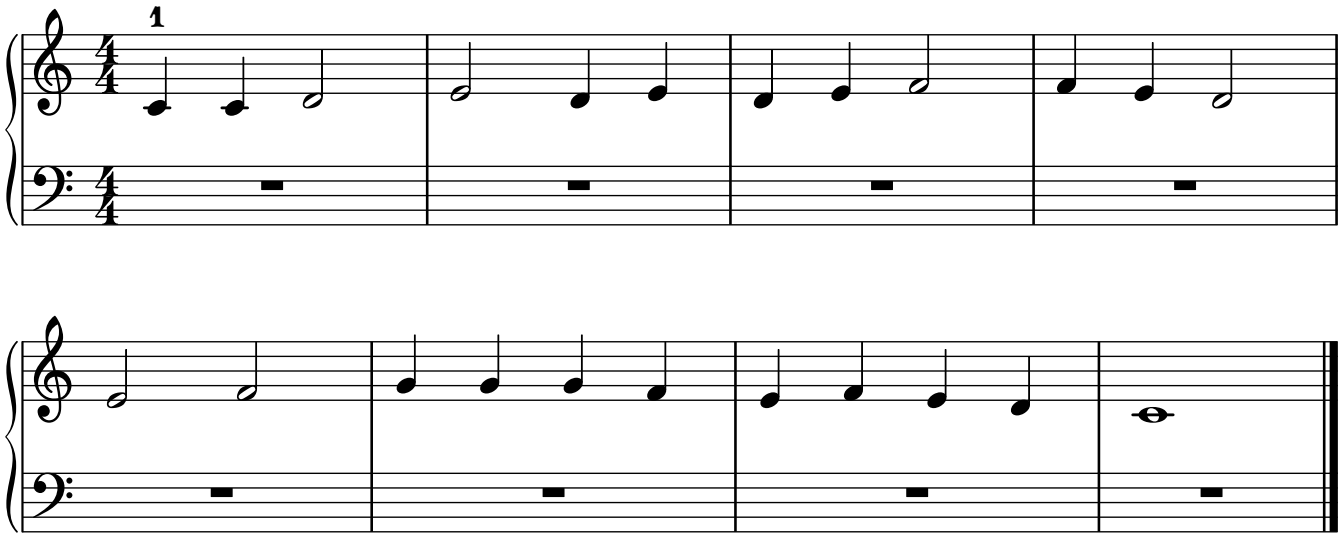


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1.29



1.30



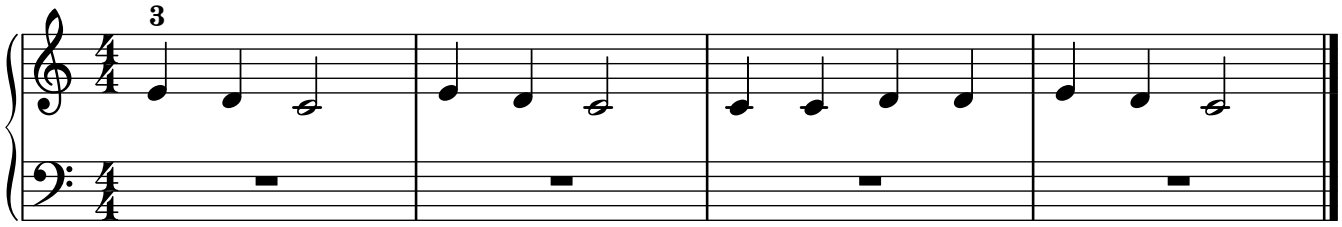
Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Hot Cross Buns ♩ = 72

Traditional (bar 3 simplified to quarter notes)
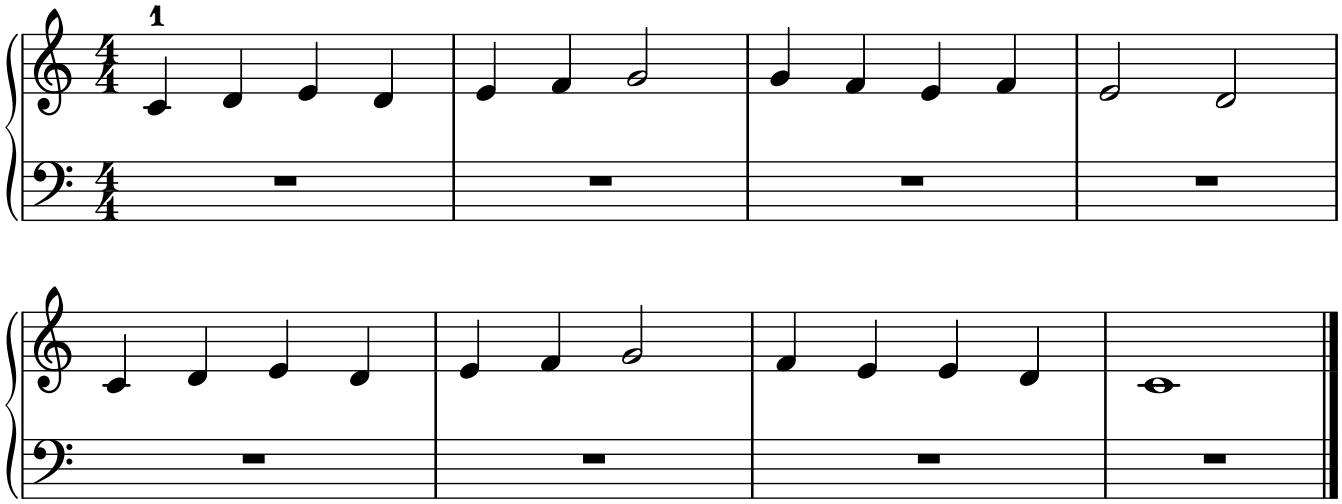
Three notes, one pattern. Bars 1, 2 and 4 are almost the same. One new move: after each C, skip back up to E (finger 1 to finger 3).



First Steps ♩ = 72

Original

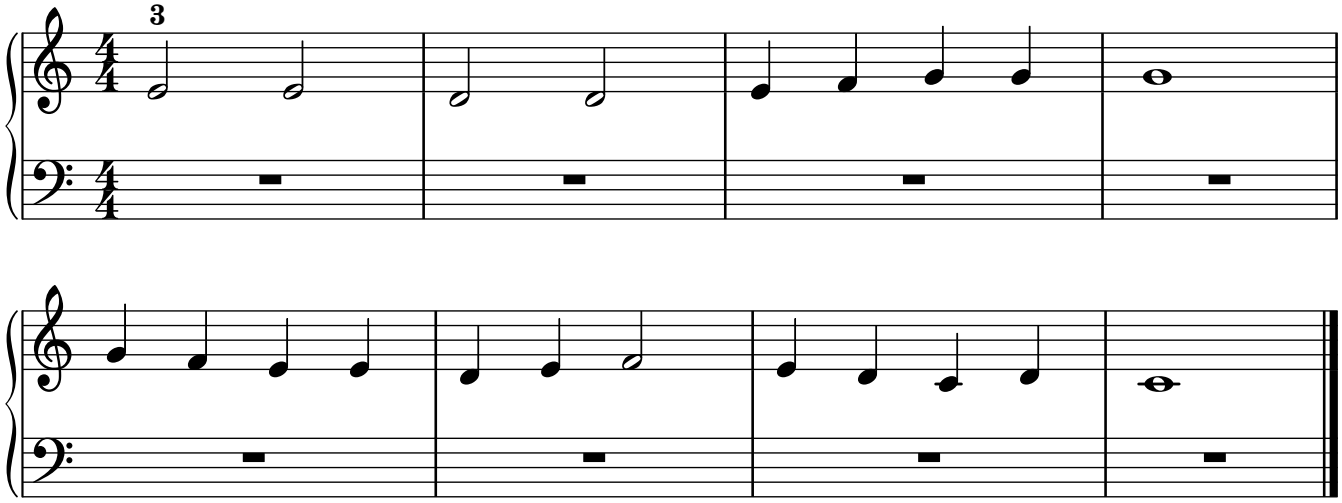
A question (bars 1-4) and an answer (bars 5-8). The answer starts exactly like the question.



Seesaw ♩ = 76

Original

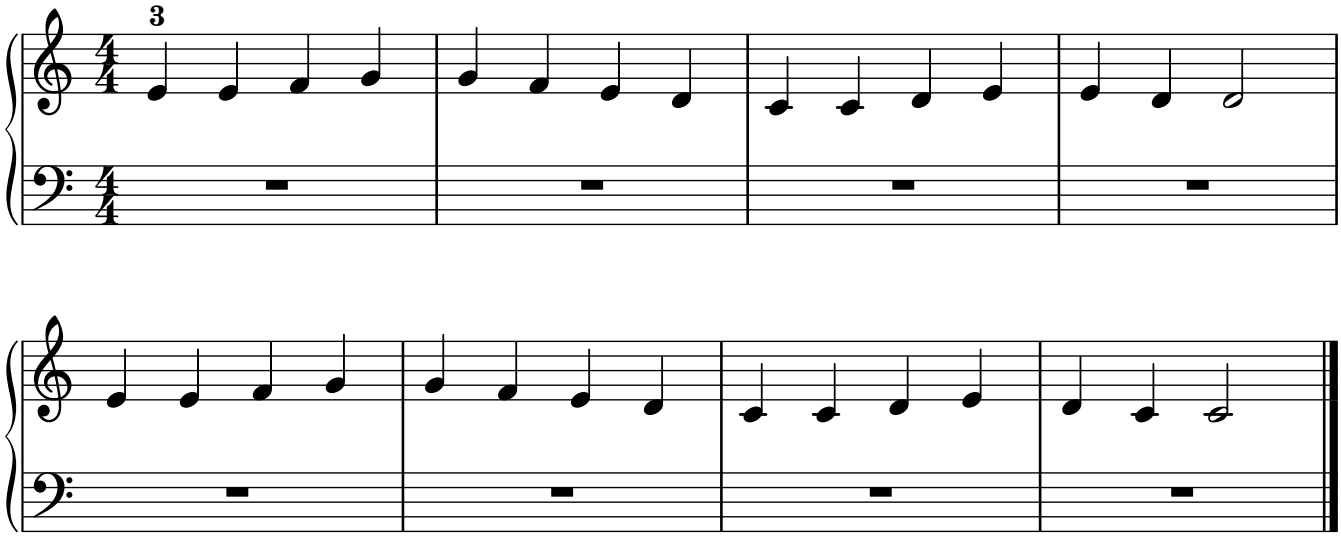
Repeated notes stay on the same line or space. Keep the half notes full: count 1 - 2, 3 - 4.



Ode to Joy ♩ = 80

Ludwig van Beethoven (1824), simplified

The famous theme from the Ninth Symphony uses only your five C-position notes. Bars 1-3 and 5-7 are identical; only the endings differ.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 2?

- Play five Part C exercises you have not played before, at 66 beats per minute.
- Pass if you keep the beat going to the end of each one, with no more than one stop per exercise.
- Pass if at least 9 notes out of 10 are right.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 2. If not, play Part B and C exercises again in a week; by then you will have forgotten them.